> Belief in the ability of deterrence and compellence to prevent nuclear war was immensely reassuring to everyone. Downplaying uncertainty, denying loss of control and miscalculated escalation, exaggerating rationality, risk management, and control over nuclear weapons and the military, buttressed presidential authority and justified Kennedy's nuclear arms buildup and the off-scale military budget.[42]

Proximity is in the eye of the beholder

One seemingly self-evident lesson to be drawn from the crisis is that land-based nuclear missiles close to the territory of an adversary (and in particular its capital) are a recipe for confrontation, if not crisis. Less than twenty years after the Cuban missile crisis, NATO decided to deploy land-based nuclear missiles within range of the USSR (including Moscow). The axiom (or cliché) that those who fail to learn from history are doomed to repeat it springs to mind. NATO's decision materially contributed to a crisis in East-West relations that became known as the Second Cold War. Some believe that in November 1983 there was a genuine threat of nuclear war, in what is known as the 'Able Archer' crisis. This involved Soviet misperception of an annual NATO command post training exercise that some in Moscow may have interpreted as preparation for a US first strike. Historians disagree about the seriousness of the crisis (about which the West was largely unaware at the time). Indeed, some even doubt there was much of a crisis at all.[43]

How far the events of 1983 can be compared to those of 1962 is a matter of dispute. In one key respect, though, the deployments were comparable. Both involved 'extended deterrence' – the idea that nuclear weapons would deter an attack on an ally (or allies) by threatening the aggressor with nuclear attack. As noted, there remains debate about the relative weight to be attached to the differing Soviet objectives in 1962. Strategic inferiority was clearly a central objective, though many historians still attach importance to deterring aggression by Washington. Yet, when push was